

FOOTBALL (SOCCER)

The World's Most Popular Sport

Introduction

Football, known as soccer in some countries, is the most popular team sport in the world, played by over 250 million players in more than 200 countries. The objective is simple: score more goals than the opposing team by getting the ball into the opponent's net using any part of the body except the hands and arms.[sport-wiki](#)

History of Football

The exact origins of football are debated, but the sport's history spans more than a century across many countries.[sport-wiki](#)

Ancient Origins:

- In ancient China, a game called "Cuju" was played as early as the 2nd century BC, which FIFA recognized in 2004 as the earliest form of football.[sport-wiki](#)
- Various ball games existed in ancient Greece, Rome, and among indigenous peoples of the Americas.

Modern Football Development:

- The first official Rules of the Game were introduced on December 7, 1863, by the Football Association of England.[sport-wiki](#)
 - Today, the Rules of the Game are established by the International Football Association Board (IFAB), which includes FIFA (4 votes) and representatives from the English, Scottish, Northern Irish, and Welsh football associations.[sport-wiki](#)
 - The FIFA World Cup, first held in 1930, has become the most watched sporting event globally.
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Basic Objective

Two teams of eleven players each compete to score goals by advancing the ball into the opponent's goal. The team with the most goals at the end of the match wins. Players can use their feet, head, chest, or any body part except hands and arms to control and pass the ball. Only the goalkeeper is permitted to use hands, and only within their own penalty area.[sport-wiki](#)

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Rules of the Game

Match Duration

- A football match consists of two halves of 45 minutes each.[sport-wiki](#)
- There is a 15-minute halftime break between halves.[sport-wiki](#)
- Additional time (stoppage time) may be added at the referee's discretion for injuries, substitutions, and other delays.[sport-wiki](#)
- In knockout competitions, if the match is tied after 90 minutes, extra time (two 15-minute periods) and/or penalty shootouts may be used.[sport-wiki](#)

Team Composition

- Each team consists of a maximum of eleven players on the pitch at the same time.[sport-wiki](#)
- One player must be designated as the goalkeeper.[sport-wiki](#)
- Teams may have substitutes on the bench (typically 3-5 substitutions allowed in most competitions).[sport-wiki](#)
- A match cannot continue if a team has fewer than 7 players.[sport-wiki](#)

Key Rules

1. **Offside Rule:** A player is in an offside position if they are nearer to the opponent's goal line than both the ball and the second-last opponent when the ball is played to them.[sport-wiki](#)
2. **Fouls and Misconduct:** Dangerous play, tripping, pushing, holding, or handling the ball deliberately results in free kicks or penalty kicks.[sport-wiki](#)
3. **Free Kicks:** Awarded for fouls; can be direct (can score directly) or indirect (must touch another player first).[sport-wiki](#)
4. **Penalty Kick:** Awarded for fouls committed inside the defending team's penalty area.[sport-wiki](#)
5. **Throw-ins:** When the ball goes out over the sideline, play restarts with a throw-in by the opposing team.[sport-wiki](#)

6. **Goal Kicks and Corner Kicks:** Awarded when the ball goes out over the goal line.[sport-wiki](#)
 7. **Yellow and Red Cards:** Yellow cards warn players for misconduct; two yellow cards equal a red card (ejection from the match).[sport-wiki](#)
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Playing Area (Pitch)

Field Dimensions

- **Length:** 100-130 yards (90-120 meters)
- **Width:** 50-100 yards (45-90 meters)
- International matches: 110-120 yards × 70-80 yards

Key Markings

- **Center Circle:** 10-yard radius from the center spot
- **Penalty Area:** 18 yards from each goal post, extending 18 yards into the field
- **Goal Area:** 6 yards from each goal post, extending 6 yards into the field
- **Penalty Spot:** 12 yards from the goal line
- **Corner Arcs:** Quarter circles with 1-yard radius at each corner

Goals

- Width: 8 yards (7.32 meters)
 - Height: 8 feet (2.44 meters)
 - Goal nets attached to catch the ball when a goal is scored
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Equipment

Player Equipment[digitalhub.fifa+1](#)

1. **Shirt/Jersey:** With sleeves, displaying team colors and player number
2. **Shorts:** Matching team colors
3. **Stockings/Socks:** Covering shin guards completely
4. **Shin Guards:** Mandatory protective equipment for lower legs
5. **Football Boots/Cleats:** Designed for traction on grass or artificial surfaces

The Ball[digitalhub.fifa](#)

- **Shape:** Spherical
- **Material:** Suitable material (typically leather or synthetic)
- **Circumference:** 68-70 cm (27-28 inches)
- **Weight:** 410-450 grams (14-16 ounces) at match start
- **Pressure:** 0.6-1.1 atmospheres at sea level

Additional Equipment

- Goalkeeper gloves (optional but standard)
- No dangerous equipment allowed (jewelry, hard casts, etc.)[digitalhub.fifa](https://www.fifa.com/digitalhub)

Page 3: Positions, Tactics & Major Competitions

Player Positions

Goalkeeper (GK)

- The only player allowed to use hands (within penalty area)
- Primary role: Prevent goals, organize defense
- Wears distinct colored jersey from teammates

Defenders

- **Center Backs (CB):** Central defensive players, strong in aerial duels and tackling
- **Full Backs (FB/LB/RB):** Defend wide areas, support attacks down the flanks
- **Wing Backs (LWB/RWB):** More attacking-minded than traditional full backs

Midfielders

- **Defensive Midfielder (CDM/DM):** Protects defense, breaks up opposition attacks
- **Central Midfielder (CM):** Links defense and attack, controls tempo
- **Attacking Midfielder (CAM/AM):** Creates scoring opportunities, plays behind strikers
- **Wide Midfielders/Wingers (LM/RM/LW/RW):** Play on flanks, deliver crosses, cut inside to shoot

Forwards/Strikers

- **Center Forward (CF):** Main goal scorer, holds up play
 - **Striker (ST):** Primary goal scorer, leads the attack
 - **Second Striker/Support Striker:** Plays behind main striker, creates and scores
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Common Formations

1. **4-4-2:** Four defenders, four midfielders, two strikers (balanced)
 2. **4-3-3:** Four defenders, three midfielders, three forwards (attacking)
 3. **4-2-3-1:** Four defenders, two defensive mids, three attacking mids, one striker (versatile)
 4. **3-5-2:** Three defenders, five midfielders, two strikers (midfield control)
 5. **5-3-2:** Five defenders, three midfielders, two strikers (defensive)
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Tactics and Strategies

Attacking Tactics

- **Possession Play:** Maintaining ball control to create opportunities
- **Counter-Attacking:** Quick transitions from defense to attack
- **Wing Play:** Using wide areas to deliver crosses
- **Through Balls:** Passing behind defensive lines for strikers to run onto

Defensive Tactics

- **High Press:** Pressing opponents in their own half
 - **Low Block:** Defending deep in own half
 - **Man Marking:** Each defender marks specific opponent
 - **Zonal Marking:** Defenders cover specific areas
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Major Competitions

International

- **FIFA World Cup:** Held every 4 years, most prestigious tournament
- **UEFA European Championship:** European national teams

- **Copa América:** South American national teams
- **Africa Cup of Nations:** African national teams
- **AFC Asian Cup:** Asian national teams
- **CONCACAF Gold Cup:** North/Central American teams

Club Competitions

- **UEFA Champions League:** Top European clubs
 - **English Premier League:** England's top division
 - **La Liga:** Spain's top division
 - **Serie A:** Italy's top division
 - **Bundesliga:** Germany's top division
 - **Copa Libertadores:** South American clubs
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Interesting Facts

- Football is played professionally in over 200 countries worldwide.[sport-wiki](#)
 - The FIFA World Cup is the most watched sporting event globally, with billions of viewers.[sport-wiki](#)
 - Pelé (Brazil) is the only player to win three World Cups (1958, 1962, 1970).[sport-wiki](#)
 - The fastest recorded goal was scored in 2.8 seconds.[sport-wiki](#)
 - A football match is controlled by one referee assisted by two assistant referees (linesmen).[sport-wiki](#)
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Benefits of Playing Football

- Improves cardiovascular health and endurance
- Develops teamwork and communication skills
- Enhances coordination, balance, and agility
- Builds strength, particularly in legs and core
- Promotes social interaction and sportsmanship